and promising that his team would soon be successful. After the successful launch of SLV-3, however, Dhawan asked Kalam to address the press.

'Own up the team's failure, let the team take the credit for the success—that was Dhawan,' Kalam would say.

Soon Kalam became group director, aerodynamics and was moved to the ISRO headquarters as director, launch vehicles. From there, in 1982, Kalam went back to where he came from—the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) —to earn the name 'India's missile man.'

SLV-3 had another failure on 31 May 1981, and we wound up SLV-3 with another successful launch, on 17 April 1983. Now the focus was on PSLV, and I was the project director for the second and fourth stages of the rocket. Powering the second stage would be my pet engine Vikas. Just when I was considering myself lucky, towards the end of September 1983 Gowarikar dropped a bomb.

One morning Muthunayagam called me into his room and gave me a letter. It said I have been transferred to the programme planning and evaluation group with effect from 3 October 1983. If the quality control group was then considered a dump yard, the programme planning and evaluation group was virtually a graveyard. We had learned in Vernon that such groups are vital in planning and execution of any project, but things hadn't moved forward in India, and these groups were still considered home for the inefficient and those who the bosses just didn't like.

Muthunayagam stated the obvious: Gowarikar didn't want me in the propulsion group anymore. Not surprisingly, Muthunayagam didn't protest my transfer. And I had to fight another battle for myself. I went to Gowarikar. There was no time to beat around the bush here.

'Why did you transfer me?' I asked.

Gowarikar kept a calm face. 'It's a routine thing,' he said. 'For a while we have been discussing about rotating people in different groups.'

It was a typical bureaucratic tactic. When there is no reason or logic for a decision, call it routine. There was no point arguing with this man, at least for now. I wrote to Dhawan. When there was no reply for a couple of weeks, I went to the ISRO headquarters in Bangalore.

I asked Dhawan the same question.

I knew Dhawan had always been fair to me, but he had to be fair with procedures too. He said it was the centre director's prerogative to transfer